

Higuchi, he would have reached the finals of the men's 57kg category and been assured of a medal. Instead, he was ragdolled into submission.

There was no time for self-pity. The 21-year-old rushed out of the competition arena and began his weight-control regime. He had five kilos to lose before his weigh-in the next morning. By reaching the semifinal round, he had earned the right to wrestle for bronze through repechage. But to compete the next day, he needed to make weight.

Making weight can be harder than wrestling itself. The 'cut' had already taken a toll on the men's 57kg category. On the first day of competition, Iran's Alireza Sarlak, a former world silver medallist and medal contender, failed to make weight and was scratched from the competition.

Russian-turned-Albanian Zelimkhan Abakarov, a former world champion, barely managed to make weight. He struggled even to step on the mat. He had beaten Aman 10-0 the last time they met at the World Championships, but drained of energy, he lost 0-12 to the Indian in the quarterfinals in Paris. However, what probably hit closest to home was when Aman's compatriot, Vinesh Phogat, had an assured medal snatched from her just a few days ago after she was disqualified from the final of the women's 50kg competition.

Aman wasn't taking any chances.

He pulled on his black sweatsuit and headed to the mat in the training hall. He shadow-practised by himself for the next hour and a half, then hit the gym and worked out some more. When he stood on the scales three hours later, he saw what he was looking for: 56.80 kg. It took three sessions and three checks for Aman to rest easy.

Not a drop of water or a morsel of food was consumed. Hungry and thirsty, but mostly relieved, he went to bed.

Hours later, Aman felt a bit uneasy as he approached the scales. Thankfully, he was still under. At 7:30 am, he walked into the weigh-in room and made weight.

"It was hard, but not anything more than what he can do. This is what we do," coach Virender Singh said later about how much a part of the routine is cutting weight.

Only after passing his weigh-in did Aman finally allow himself to drink something. By the evening, he was ready to go.

That spelled trouble for his opponent, Darian Toi Cruz of Puerto Rico. A former collegiate champion in the USA, he has also represented the USA in international competitions before switching to his current team. He is good, but the Indian had a hunger that would not be satiated by food.

Cruz put up a challenge early on and even led 3-2, but Aman was relentless like a pit bull. He kept hand-fighting, snapping Cruz's neck down, and sapping his energy. As the fight wore on, the Indian's pace took a toll. A close fight at 6-5 became a blowout as Aman racked up takedown after takedown. He won 13-5. By winning bronze, Aman joined an elite list of Indian men's Olympic wrestling medallists. This list includes two-time Olympic medallist Sushil Kumar, 2012 bronze medallist Yogeshwar Dutt, Tokyo silver medallist Ravi Dahiya, and Bajrang Punia, who won bronze in the same edition.

All of them have emerged from an *akhara* that is as important to Indian wrestling as La Masia is to Spanish football.

There are no easy days at Chhatrasal *akhara* in New Delhi's Model Town neighbourhood. It is an all-male boot camp, where boys live cramped in a room of five or more. The electricity doesn't always work. In the winter, you shiver. In the summer, you sweat. The place constantly smells of sweat. Chhatrasal teaches not just wrestling but pain tolerance — the willingness to undergo suffering for the promise of success. There's no place for weakness or softness here. If you think you are special, you will be quickly cut down to size. There's always someone as hungry as you, willing to do more than you. You do what you have to do, or you go

home. Despite its reputation, every other day, young boys come here on their own or are brought here from all over Haryana with dreams of becoming great wrestlers. If there is one place where dreams of becoming champion wrestlers are realised, it is at the Chhatrasal *akhara*.

But Chhatrasal isn't just an academy for Aman. It's also home. When he was 11 years old, then a scrawny and shy boy, he was brought here by his uncle. Although he had wrestled at an *akhara* in the village of Birohar, in Haryana's Jhajhar district, that wasn't the only reason he was brought here. He was brought in because he had nowhere else to go.

Aman doesn't like to talk much about his early life. He has a painful past. When he was just 10, his mother died by suicide. His father, grief-stricken, died the same way a year later. His family wasn't rich. An uncle brought him to Chhatrasal soon after — if not to be a wrestler, then at least to get three meals a day while helping out some of the more established players.

Many of the boys at Chhatrasal are homesick. That's never been an option for Aman. Since he arrived at Chhatrasal, Aman's life has revolved around training and competition.

"He has almost no distractions. He has a singular-minded focus on training," says coach Praveen Kumar, one of the coaches at Chhatrasal *akhara*. "Chhatrasal Stadium is my home. The wrestlers here are my family. If someone asks me to go somewhere for Diwali, I don't agree. I make it clear that I'm not leaving

